Maryland's Eastern Shore Faces the Steepest Barriers to Economic Mobility

A county-level look at income, housing, and access, 2015–2019 vs. 2020–2024 | Swetha Sree Madan Mohan | November 2026

Why I looked at this

Where you live in Maryland has a lot to do with how hard it is to get ahead. I wanted to see how much that varies from county to county, and whether things got better or worse over the last five years. I pulled public Census and BLS data for all 24 jurisdictions, compared two survey periods, and combined seven indicators (income, poverty, rent burden, education, broadband, health insurance, and unemployment) into a single Mobility Barriers Index.

What I found

- **Rent burdens are heaviest on the Eastern Shore.** All five jurisdictions where the largest share of renters spend 30% or more of their income on rent are on the Shore. In Kent County, it's close to 6 in 10 renters.
- **Barriers cluster in Baltimore City, the Eastern Shore, and Western Maryland.** Baltimore City (index score 1.06) and Dorchester County (1.05) rank highest, followed by Somerset, Allegany, and Caroline. The central Maryland suburbs face the fewest barriers, with Howard County lowest at −1.31.
- **In 8 counties, housing got harder to afford even after adjusting for inflation.** Real median income dropped while rent burden went up. Queen Anne's saw the biggest squeeze (income down 5.2%, rent burden up 6.2 points), followed by Caroline and Baltimore County. Montgomery and Carroll are on the list too, though their changes were small.
- **Broadband and poverty tend to go together.** Counties with fewer households on broadband have higher poverty (r = −0.77), and education shows a similar pattern (r = −0.65). With only 24 counties, that's a relationship worth noting, not proof that one causes the other.

Highest rent burden, 2020–2024

County	Renters paying 30%+ of income	Median household income
Kent County	59.6%	$80,147
Dorchester County	56.0%	$61,839
Caroline County	55.8%	$68,457
Worcester County	55.3%	$81,745
Queen Anne's County	54.4%	$112,826

What this could mean

- Housing support aimed at the Eastern Shore would reach the counties where renters are under the most pressure.
- Queen Anne's is a good reminder that income doesn't tell the whole story. Its median income is well above most of the state, yet it ranks fifth for rent burden.
- Counties that combine high poverty with low broadband access are natural candidates for digital access programs.

About the data

U.S. Census Bureau American Community Survey 5-year estimates (2015–2019 and 2020–2024) and BLS Local Area Unemployment Statistics. Incomes are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. ACS figures are survey estimates, and small counties like Somerset and Kent have wide margins of error. Somerset's large swings (income up 40%, rent burden down 18.9 points) are most likely sampling noise. The 2020–2024 period also includes the pandemic. The index weights all seven indicators equally and compares counties with each other rather than against a fixed benchmark.

Personal project built with Python, SQL (DuckDB), and Tableau using only public data. Not affiliated with or endorsed by any Maryland state agency.
Dashboard: Overall dashboard link | *Code:* *Github Code*